

The Cognitive-Developmental Approach to Coaching

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INTRODUCTION

The cognitive-developmental approach is based on research studies that suggest that people differ in ways that could not be explained by personality types, learning styles or personal preferences, all of which are usually seen as relatively stable for each individual. This approach suggests that people differ not only from other people but also undergo significant changes in themselves, for example in the way they make meaning of their experiences. The changes of these capacities occur in a logical sequence of stages throughout the life of the individual. They influence the depth and complexity of what each individual can notice and therefore operate on and change. This development can be further stimulated and facilitated by appropriate support and challenge within the coaching process. Understanding developmental trajectories may help coaches to be better equipped to address the diverse needs of their clients.

This chapter opens with a short history of the approach; it is followed by a discussion of its main assumptions and suggested applications for coaching. It will be compared with other theoretical traditions useful for coaching. Examples will be provided for applying this approach to different coaching contexts and genres with an evaluation made of its strengths and limitations.

A brief history of the tradition

Three major areas of research gave rise to principal strands within this approach.

- The first strand began with the important work of Jean Piaget (1976). It emphasizes developmental changes in reasoning and meaning-making which extend, for example, to moral reasoning (Kohlberg, 1969); intellectual development (Perry, 1970); reflective judgment (King & Kitchener, 1994); and "orders of mind" (Kegan, 1982, 1994).
- The second strand is ego-development, with its origins in the research of Jane Loevinger (1976, 1987). It focuses on the development of self-identity and the maturity of interpersonal relationships and has been further extended to include post-autonomous ego development by Cook-Greuter (1999, 2004) and action logics by Torbert (1991); Torbert & Associates (2004).
- The foundation of the third strand is the research of Clare Graves (1970) into levels of existence, which was later extended into "worldviews" and "values" by Beck and Cowan (1996) and is known as "Spiral Dynamics".

There are other theories and research findings that suggest that other aspects of personal development also occur in sequential stages, for example, emotions (Goleman, 1995), needs (Maslow, 1954) and spiritual awareness (Fowler, 1981). These aspects will be called here

"developmental lines" as suggested by Wilber (1999). All these studies are conducted in the tradition of developmental structuralism, which looks for patterns that connect specific psychological phenomena. According to this approach, individual characteristics are emergent, coming into being in a predictable and sequential way.

The continuing contribution of Ken Wilber (1999, 2000, 2006) to this approach is difficult to overestimate. He pulls together many theories and research findings relevant to this approach, creating a compelling picture of integral individual development that incorporates a range of developmental lines. Discussing the findings of these studies, he emphasizes various milestones of growth and development in each developmental line, calling them "stages of consciousness". With each successive stage or level the qualities of the previous stage remain as properties of the new stage. Therefore, with each new stage, a person can use anything learned in a previous stage and so becomes more flexible, integrated and more capable of functioning within a changing world that is also becoming more complex.

MAIN CONCEPTS AND ASSUMPTIONS

Each of the above studies identifies different stages in the developmental lines they study. As in map making, the way to divide and represent the territory is somewhat arbitrary; it is not important "how you slice and dice development" (Wilber, 2006).

However, some common patterns can be identified in the various ways suggested for "slicing the developmental pie". According to one of the patterns, development proceeds from the "pre-conventional level", which is simple and is focused only on the needs of the ego, to the "conventional", which could be seen as focused on the individual's environment and the people who are close to them. It then proceeds to the "post-conventional level", which is more complex and includes "concern about the whole world".

Stages take considerable time to develop and cannot be "skipped", because each is built upon the previous one, and in a particular way. Wilber (2006) calls this "holarchy", which is similar to the relationship between atoms, molecules, cells and whole organisms. Holarchy implies that it is not possible to go from atoms to cells "skipping" molecules. Each developmental line (cognitive, emotional, moral, etc.) is unfolding in the same way but at a different pace for each particular person. This means that someone could be, for example, at the highest stage intellectually, the lowest stage morally and somewhere in the middle interpersonally.

This, of course, makes the topic of overall development of individuals very complex. Wilber suggests that although substantial empirical evidence demonstrates that each line develops through these holarchical stages in an invariant sequence, nonetheless, because all two dozen of them develop relatively independently, overall growth and development is a massively complex, overlapping, nonlinear affair, following no set sequence whatsoever (Wilber, 1999: 291-2).

Figure 9.1 (in the original chapter) represents a snapshot in time of how an individual's development might look if we were able to measure each developmental line, showing the lines (needs, cognitive, spiritual, emotional, self, moral, values) at different heights. This representation, however abstract

and tentative, could be useful in dispelling the myths of the simplicity of categorizing people and the validity of quick conclusions about their overall level of development. This may also indicate the futility of attempts to use one line for describing the level of development in another.

At the same time representations of developmental lines, whether linear or spiral, create a natural curiosity about the relationship between the lines: which line is more "important"? Is there a central line or is there one yardstick against which all of them could be measured? Cook-Greuter (1999), for example, makes a case for an essential connection between the cognitive and ego-development lines, because "it is the ego whose main function is to generate coherent meaning" (Cook-Greuter, 1999: 14).

There are also a number of controversies about the role of the cognitive line. Wilber (2006) describes several propositions that attempt to explain the role of cognition in relation to all other lines. One of them suggests that the cognitive line could be a special one: growth in the cognitive line is necessary but not sufficient for growth in other lines, since one has to be aware of something in order to act on it, need it, value it, etc. Another explanation suggests that the yardstick is consciousness itself. If consciousness is defined as "the degree of openness or emptiness" it could be said to serve as the "shared altitude" along which all development lines move. As such it is not a line itself but a "space" in which lines arise.

It is important to notice that Wilber defines cognition as "the capacity to take perspectives". He even suggests that cognitive development could be measured in terms of the number of others with whom you can identify and the number of perspectives you can take. This is why Kegan's (1982) theory, which explores "orders of mind" and represents a cognitive developmental line, is a good one to use as an example of the cognitive-developmental approach in the context of coaching.

GOALS AND TASKS OF THIS TRADITION

It is important to notice that cognitive-developmental theories were not developed for coaching or any other kind of developmental intervention. The purpose of the research behind them was to:

- understand human nature
- explain the differences between people
- describe what constitutes "development" when significant changes in individuals are noticed
- design measures for identifying the stages of development in individuals.

The task of influencing these kinds of changes was secondary. In the author's view the main goal of the cognitive-developmental approach, as in fact of any other approach to coaching, is to facilitate the process of making specific changes that are chosen by the client. Psychological support is very important when an individual is facing transition or a new developmental task, and that is what all coaches are aiming to provide. What a "developmentally-minded" coach may bring into this, and what is crucial for the quality of this support, is, according to Kegan, a presence of someone "who can see, recognise, and understand who the person is and who he or she is becoming" (Kegan, 1982: 260).

When clients have an explicit interest in a wider task of overall individual development, cognitive-developmental coaches are better placed than others to support them. In order to do this:

- It is useful to identify what developmental lines are the most important for the coaching task and where along the continuum of these lines a person may be.
- Coaches have to be sufficiently aware of the mechanism of change and transition between the stages in order to provide the client with appropriate support and challenge.
- Coaches have to be aware of their own stages of development in order to reflect on their own role in the coaching process and the dynamics of the coaching relationship.

The knowledge of this approach is also important for coaches because it draws attention to their own development and enriches their capacity for reflection and effective interaction with others. With each new stage they reach they become more capable of taking a number of perspectives on situations and of understanding more people (Bachkirova & Cox, 2007).

Kegan's theory and specific features of the coaching process

Kegan's theory suggests that, as human beings, we have two tendencies that are rarely in perfect balance. The first is to differentiate ourselves from the environment and others, to be autonomous. The second tendency is to be included, to belong. The adaptive requirement of human nature is to pursue both differentiation and integration. Therefore the development of any organism is a balancing act in which one constantly negotiates "the self" in relation to "the other". At the same time, within oneself, there is a continuous process of recognizing and differentiating elements of self that were previously so integral to the self that they could not be noticed.

The shift from what is perceived to be self (subject) to something that can be seen as elements of self (object) allows a new way of differentiating oneself from and relating to others. Things that are Subject in Kegan's theory can prompt us to action but cannot be observed or reflected on. We cannot stand back and take a look at them because we are embedded in them. On the other hand, things that are Object for us are "those elements of our knowing or organizing that we can reflect on, handle, look at, be responsible for, relate to each other, take control of, internalize, assimilate, or otherwise operate upon" (Kegan, 1994: 32). To be Subject is to "see with" rather than to "see through" (Drath, 1990).

A good example is "cultural blindness": we see with our culture-bound norms and expectations, accept them as given, and cannot examine them for what they are. Our cultural heritage is something we are, not something we have. A cognitive-developmental shift, however, is possible when we become aware of culturally determined differences and the distance they create from others. Such understanding could make cultural influences an Object, opening up new ways of seeing ourselves and of relating to others.

It is natural, therefore, that the more individuals can take as Object, the more complex their worldview becomes, because they can examine and act upon more things. The mechanism of the shift from Subject to Object could be considered as an essential element of coaching. It is one of the functions of coaches to watch for the re-absorption of insight in the client and to help build "psychological

muscle" in order to hold something out from a person as an Object. As Berger and Fitzgerald (2002: 31) say: "one of the most powerful interventions coaches can provide is simply help to keep critical insights alive for their clients".

Here is an example from the coaching process. In his new role of head of department a client received feedback suggesting that his way of one-to-one communication with people made some of his staff uncomfortable. It appeared that the coachee's style involved unusually long pauses that people perceived as withdrawals, which made the more self-conscious colleagues feel insecure. The client was not aware of this; his style was so much a part of who he was that he could not reflect on its effect on other people. As a result of coaching, his style changed from being Subject into Object, leading to the client's increased ability to notice it and modify it when necessary.

Kegan (1982) calls the five periods of relative stability between these significant shifts "Orders of Mind" through which people evolve. The development process is a combination of internal and external factors for each individual, but can be stimulated and facilitated by appropriate support and challenge, for example from within the coaching process.

Table 9.1: Five stages of development according to Kegan's theory

Order 1

Subject: impulses, perceptions. Object: reflections (sensing, moving). Cognitive style: pre-operational simplicity. Self: emerging ego through ownership of what is "mine". Conscious preoccupation: safety and gratification of basic needs. Children act on impulse. They are subject to perceptions, so if perception changes the world also changes. They cannot imagine that others may have different opinions of the same things, cannot hold ideas in their mind for long and need to be reminded of the rules.

Order 2

Subject: needs, interests, wishes. Object: impulses, perceptions. Cognitive style: concrete operational, black and white thinking. Self: "I am what I want". Others: competing for goods and power. Conscious preoccupation: gaining advantages and protecting oneself. With the ability to control impulses comes a sense of freedom and power; those at this stage are now synonymous with their needs and wishes. They see others as helpers or barriers to getting what they want and follow rules mostly to avoid punishment.

Order 3

Subject: the interpersonal, mutuality. Object: needs, interests, wishes. Cognitive style: ability for abstract thinking and self-reflection. Self: defined in terms of internalized expectations of important others. Conscious preoccupation: social acceptance, status and prestige, moral "shoulds and oughts". At this stage the person has needs, not is his or her needs, so others are understood as also having needs. However, they are now their relationship; expectations of others are so important that this may cause difficulties in making decisions and give rise to issues of self-esteem. Kegan believes that people in the Third order feel "in over their heads" much of the time.

Order 4

Subject: authorship, identity, psychic administration, ideology. Object: the interpersonal, mutuality. Cognitive style: can see multiplicity and patterns, critical and analytical. Self: strong ego with interest in deep self-understanding and awareness of self-deception. Conscious preoccupation: achievement of long-term personal goals according to inner standards; pursuit of truth. A person at this stage now has the relationship; a self that may exist outside of relationship with others, with a sense of autonomy and identity. They can feel empathy and take others' views into consideration without being torn apart by them, because they have their own system with which to make decisions.

Order 5

Subject: inter-individuality, inter-penetrability of self-systems. Object: authorship, identity, psychic administration, ideology. Cognitive style: systems view and meaning-making as interpretation; tolerance of ambiguity; change from linear logic to holistic understanding. Self: integration of all aspects of self including shadow; capacity for interdependent self-definition. At this stage a person has identity and can explore his or her own self-system, recognizing the limitation of having an inner system. They are less prone to black and white thinking and apply fewer dichotomies in their evaluations of the world.

Supporting clients across orders of mind

Here is an example of how a coach may support a client at a Third order of mind whose role has Fourth order expectations, a situation that can arise when a successful client is promoted to a new, more complex role. The client may feel overwhelmed because the Fourth order complexity of the role requires him to evaluate and prioritize demands without the guidance of a third party, while his boss expects him to take the initiative. Berger and Fitzgerald (2002) suggest that a developmentally-oriented coach can support a client at the Third order of mind by, for example:

- helping to identify and articulate the expectations that are causing strain and confusion
- exploring with the client what sources of information or judgment might be available to support their decision making
- helping the client to craft a decision-making process
- identifying ways to have constructive discussions with bosses and peers
- reframing any sense of defeat and failure that the client might feel into a developmental opportunity.

The challenge for people changing from the Third to the Fourth order is to question the infallibility of external guides and to trust their internal, self-authored guide. The challenge of people who move from the Fourth to the Fifth order, in contrast, is to question the infallibility of their own self-authored system and to see the need to transcend their reliance on it (Berger & Fitzgerald, 2002).

The cognitive-developmental approach is also known for the complexity of its theory and for its labour-intensive measurements used to identify developmental stages. Lahey and associates (1988) developed the subject-object interview (SOI), used for the assessment of 21 gradations within Kegan's orders of mind, requiring 60-90 minutes of recorded interview and highly skilful scoring. There is also the Washington University Sentence Completion Test used to measure Loevinger's

(1976) stages, updated by Cook-Greuter (2004) as the Leadership Development Profile (LDP).

The cognitive-developmental approach does not imply the use of specific tools and techniques of coaching. It implies careful consideration of the appropriateness of all tools and techniques that different approaches might offer to each level of development of clients. The actual helping process could be described as an artful balance of support and challenge appropriate for each stage of development. It is the coach as a person, rather than the application of particular techniques or methods, that makes a difference in coaching practice.

COMPARING THIS TRADITION

This approach differs from others in terms of its main philosophical assumption about human nature. Traditional psychoanalysis takes a more sceptical view of human development, while humanistic psychology works on the assumption of unlimited potential for the growth of each individual. According to the developmentalists an individual may progress through the various levels, but equally may go into reverse, while humanity itself is always moving forward.

The cognitive-developmental approach was not originally developed for counselling as were most other approaches. Therefore it has no stake in claiming any particular psychological "territory" as, for example, cognitive-behavioural or transpersonal approaches do. Instead, development can be seen from any angle (emotional, rational, behavioural, etc.) and any other approach to coaching is valued as contributing to the overall developmental process. The focus of this approach is on vertical rather than horizontal changes. Horizontal changes, such as in skills, performance, specific behaviours and level of confidence, can occur as a result of coaching or just through exposure to life, but not all of them will contribute to the developmental shifts in which this approach is interested.

RELATIONSHIP WITH CONTEXTS AND GENRES OF COACHING

There is an obvious connection between the cognitive-developmental approach and developmental coaching, which is concerned with holistic changes in the person. If clients are dealing with important dilemmas or transitions in their lives, the cognitive-developmental perspective may help coaches and clients to understand that this transition may be not just an adjustment to environmental changes but also an internal process that has specific features.

For transformational coaching some specific pointers may be given as to what may constitute a transformation and under what circumstances it is likely to happen. The approach may offer a different explanation of the state of being "stuck": clients who appear stuck in the Third order may need to stay attached to an important group and refuse to question anything that shakes their belief system, while others may be stuck in the Fourth order because they feel comfortable, confident and in control there.

In relation to team coaching, this approach makes clear why group work is sometimes difficult: when individuals at different levels of development are intensely involved in the same process, the chances of serious misunderstandings are numerous, although opportunities for growth may also be present.

The coach's own level of development is also important: to be most help to the client the coach should be able to recognize where the client is on the developmental line, and people find difficulty in recognizing levels of development higher than their own.

EVALUATION OF THE APPROACH AND CONCLUSIONS

Two aspects of this approach cause unease in some coaches, and there are warnings for those who might be overzealous in using it without sufficient appreciation of its complexity. The nature of development is a complex process that involves a combination of known and unknown, internal and environmental factors, and the shift from one stage to another may take years to be noticed. The theory, once understood, may be so attractive that it seduces some coaches into using it inappropriately, designing interventions to "move" clients from one stage to another. The main danger is that it may create the illusion that significant developmental shifts can be induced by sufficient motivation and effort, and may distract coaches from concerns of the client that may be more relevant and urgent.

A useful reminder is the concern of Kegan herself: "amongst the many things from which a practitioner's clients need protection is the practitioner's hopes for the client's future, however benign and sympathetic these hopes may be" (1982: 295). At the same time, the coaching process, even if it aims at specific and pragmatic goals, provides important conditions for potential developmental shifts in individuals. Coaching engagements do not need to aim at such shifts to be successful.

Coaches sometimes express unease that the approach implies a judgment about the level of development a client or coach represents, going against an implicit characteristic of coaching as non-judgmental. Developmental approaches do imply judgments, but the purpose of judgment in coaching is to facilitate a better fit between the environment and the individual's capacity for dealing with it, in the best service of the client. To assess the client's stage, coaches may use independent instruments such as the SOI or LDP (complex and time-consuming), or rely on an "educated guess", which the author would not dismiss provided the coach is developmentally-minded and is himself or herself actively engaged in the developmental process. Such a judgment remains tentative and need not be voiced; a place for a grain of mystery should always be kept in coaching, which is, to some extent, as much a mysterious process as development itself.

FURTHER READING

- Berger, J., & Fitzgerald, C. (2002). Leadership and complexity of mind: The role of executive coaching. In C. Fitzgerald & J. Berger (Eds.), *Executive coaching: Practices & perspectives* (pp. 27-58). Palo Alto, CA: Davies-Black.
 - Cook-Greuter, S. (2004). Making the case for developmental perspective. *Industrial and Commercial Training*, 36(7).
 - Kegan, R. (1994). *In over our heads*. London: Harvard University Press.
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Lectura del curso. Texto reconstruido a partir del capítulo original (The Complete Handbook of Coaching, cap. 9) para el portal SOPHIA. La Figura 9.1 y la Tabla 9.1 del original se presentan aquí en forma descriptiva.